

Topic 3: 19th Century Philippines

List of Reading Materials:

- **A Visit to the Philippine Islands**
- ***State of the Philippines in 1810* in *The Former Philippines Thru Foreign Eyes***
- **Marcelo H. Del Pilar's *Aba Guinoong Baria***
- ***The Philippine Islands* in *La Solidaridad*, Vol. 2: 1890**
- **Internal Political Condition of the Philippines in Emma Blair and James Robertson (eds.), *The Philippine Islands***
- ***Our aims* in *La Solidaridad***
- **"The Causes of the Distress of the Philippines"**
- **Album De Filipinas**

Introduction for 19th Century Philippines

The nineteenth century was a period of profound change for the Philippines. The abolition of the galleon trade in 1815 and the establishment of an export-oriented, cash crop economy led to important economic, political, and socio-cultural transformations that immensely affected the colony. For example, owing to the Philippines' engagement in the international market, economic opportunities were no longer limited to certain privileged sectors from the government and the church. Some groups of *indios naturales* had also benefitted from these developments, which, led to their upward socio-economic mobility. They became the "middle class," who, through their recently-acquired wealth, was able to send their children to Europe to study. Economic development in society, however, was uneven. The majority of the population, mostly belonging to the laboring classes, still lived in material deprivation, and oftentimes found it difficult to fulfil their pecuniary obligations to the state. These and other related events contributed to the formation of reformist and revolutionary organizations which played a crucial role in ending the Spanish control of the islands in 1898.

The set of materials included here presents the various facets of colonial life in the nineteenth century Philippines. These were written by various Spanish officials and administrators, Filipino propagandists, and foreign travelers and observers. Presented either in their entirety or a portion

from the original texts, these source materials provide a glimpse into the conditions and changes occurring in the colony at that time. Some of them highlight what reforms, projects and programs were needed to secure progress in the Philippines. Others emphasize what could happen if these measures were implemented or when things were left as they were. Ultimately, the collection will help the readers understand and appreciate the “long” nineteenth century as an important period in the history of the country.

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Bowring, John. 1859. *A Visit to the Philippine Islands*. London: Smith, Elder & Co, 202-212.

The Author and His Work

A Visit to the Philippine Islands is an account written by Sir John Bowring about his brief sojourn to the Philippines in 1858, while mourning the recent loss of his wife. Bowring, who served as British Consul at Canton (1849) and, later, governor of Hong Kong (1854-1859), wrote about his official travel to the Spanish colony in 1859, and published it in the same year. His seven-week tour on the steam-powered paddle frigate *Magicienne* covered several areas which included Manila, Laguna, and Tayabas. In *A Visit to the Philippines* (comprising 27 chapters in total), he presented an engaging narration of the political, economic, and socio-cultural life the Philippines from the time the Spaniards first set foot on the islands until the early decades of the nineteenth century. It is evident that in addition to his own insightful observations, he also used English and Spanish published materials to enrich his account. The particular text below, taken from the Chapter 12 (Ecclesiastical Authority) of the book, discusses the authority of the Church over the colonized populations, the sources and basis of this authority, and how it was liberally exercised by the different religious groups and congregations in the Philippines.

Text

It cannot be denied that, in the language of Tomas de Comyn, “the missionaries were the real ¹ conquerors of the Philippines; their arms were not, indeed, those of the warrior, but they gave laws to millions, and, scattered though they were, they established by unity of purpose and of action a permanent empire over immense multitudes of men.” Up to the present hour there are probably few parishes in which the gobernadorcillo, having received a mandate from the civil ² authority, fails to consult the friar, and the efficiency and activity of the Indian functionary in ³ giving effect to the mandate will much depend on the views the padre may take of the orders issued.

The opulence of the individual monks, and of some of the monkish fraternities in the islands, has often and naturally been a subject of reproach. The revenues received by individuals are in many localities very large, amounting in remote districts to eight or nine thousand dollars a year, and much more, it is reported, in such populous pueblos as Binondo. Some of these communities ⁴ also possess large tracts of land, whose management is superintended at periodical meetings held in the capital, when friars from the different provinces, and of the same brotherhood, are summoned to give an account of their stewardship, and to discuss the general interests of the

referring to Tomas de Comyn who wrote *The State of the Philippines in 1810*.¹

head of a town²

or “indios naturales,” referring to the native inhabitants of the Philippines³

pueblos or towns⁴

fraternity. The accumulations of the friars pass to the convents at their death, but they have little difficulty in disposing of them while living.

It has been said that the policy of the friars in the Philippines is to conduct the Indian to heaven by a pathway of flowers. Little molestation will he experience from his ghostly father, if he be strict in his religious observances, pay his regular contributions to Church and State, and exhibit those outward marks of respect and reverence which the representatives of the Deity claim as their lawful heritage; but there are many thorns amidst the flowers, and drawbacks, on the heavenly road; and the time may come when higher and nobler aspirations than those which now satisfy the poor untutored, or little tutored, Indian, will be his rule of conduct.

The personal courtesies, the kind reception and multifarious attentions which I received from the friars in every part of the Philippines naturally dispose me to look upon them with a friendly eye. I found among them men worthy of being loved and honoured, some of considerable intellectual vigour; but literary cultivation and scientific acquirements are rare. Occupied with their own concerns, they are little acquainted with mundane affairs. Politics, geography, history, have no charms for those who, even had they the disposition for study, would, in their seclusion and remoteness, have access to few of its appliances. Their convents are almost palatial, with extensive courts, grounds and gardens; their revenues frequently enormous. Though their mode of life is generally unostentatious and simple, many of them keep handsome carriages and have the best horses in the locality; and they are surrounded generally by a prostrate and superstitious population, upon whose hopes and fears, thoughts and feelings, they exercise an influence which would seem magical were it not by their devotees deemed divine. This influence, no doubt, is greatly due to the heroism, labours, sufferings and sacrifices of the early missionaries, and to the admirably organized hierarchy of the Roman Church, whose ramifications reach to the extremest points in which any of the forms or semblances of Christianity are to be discovered. Volumes upon volumes—the folio records of the proceedings of the different religious orders, little known to Protestant readers—fill the library shelves of these Catholic establishments, which are the receptacles of their religious history.

A source of influence possessed by the friars, and from which a great majority of civil functionaries are excluded, is the mastery of the native languages. All the introductory studies of ecclesiastical aspirants are dedicated to this object. No doubt they have great advantages from living habitually among the Indian people, with whom they keep up the most uninterrupted intercourse, and of whose concerns they have an intimate knowledge. One of the most obvious means of increasing the power of the civil departments would be in encouragement given to their

functionaries for the acquirement of the native idioms. I believe Spanish is not employed in the pulpits anywhere beyond the capital. In many of the pueblos there is not a single individual Indian who understands Castilian, so that the priest is often the only link between the government and the community, and, as society is now organized, a necessary link. It must be recollected, too, that the different members of the religious brotherhoods are bound together by stronger bonds and a more potent and influential organization than any official hierarchy among civilians; and the government can expect no co-operation from the priesthood in any measures which tend to the diminution of ecclesiastical authority or jurisdiction, and yet the subjection of that authority to the State, and its limitation wherever it interferes with the public well-being, is

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the great necessity and the all-important problem to be solved in the Philippines. But here, too, the *Catholic* character of the government itself presents an enormous and almost invincible difficulty. Nothing is so dear to a Spaniard in general as his religion; his orthodoxy is his pride and glory, and upon this foundation the Romish Church naturally builds up a political power and is able to intertwine its pervading influence with all the machinery of the civil government.

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Tomas de Comyn. [1810] 1917. *State of the Philippines in 1810*. In *The Former Philippines Thru Foreign Eyes*, edited by Austin Craig, pp. 357- 458. New York: D. Appleton and Company.

The *State of the Philippines in 1810* was written by Tomas de Comyn, who served, for ⁵ several years, as general manager of the Royal Philippine Company, a chartered company established in 1785. Comyn had at least three main purposes in writing this text. First, to ⁶ describe the political, economic, and socio-cultural aspects of Philippine life during the first decade of the nineteenth century. Second, to examine the pressing issues at the time, such as Moro attacks, corruption in the government, and ineptitude of public officials that, for him, impeded economic progress. Finally, to call public attention to the current state of the colony so that the government could devise a plan to advance the islands' development. His work did not evoke the attention he hoped to capture. However, it is still an important historical source as it presents a general overview of the Philippine condition a few years before the abolition of the galleon and the opening of the colony to international trade. The ⁷ specific passage below deals with land ownership, as well as the various concerns related to it, and Comyn's view on how the state could remedy these issues.

Excerpt:

Estates. The proprietors of estates in the Philippines are of four classes. The most considerable is that of the religious orders, Augustinians and Dominicans, who cultivate their respective lands on joint account, or let them out at a moderate ground-rent, which the planters pay in kind; but far from living in opulence, and accumulating the immense revenues some of the religious communities enjoy in America, they stand in need of all they earn and possess for their ⁸

maintenance, and in order to be enabled to discharge the various duties and obligations annexed to the missions with which they are entrusted.

Spanish planters. The second class comprehends the Spanish proprietors, whose number possibly does not exceed a dozen of persons, and even they labor under such disadvantages, and have to contend with so many obstacles, under the existing order of things, that, compelled to divide their lands into rice plantations, in consequence of this being the species of culture to

Tomas de Comyn. [1810] 1917. *State of the Philippines in 1810*. In *The Former Philippines Thru Foreign Eyes*, edited by Austin Craig, pp. 357-458. New York: D. Appleton and Company.

The Royal Philippine Company was granted a monopoly to import Chinese and Indian commodities⁶ into the Philippines as well as to transport goods from the colony directly to Spain.

The galleon trade—the economic lifeblood of the Philippines for more than two centuries—was⁷ officially abolished in 1815. A few years later, in 1834, the Philippines was opened to international trade.

Comyn was referring to the colonies of the Spanish Empire since the sixteenth century in central and⁸ southern America.

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which the natives are most inclined, and to devote a considerable portion of them to the grazing of horned cattle, no one of them is in a situation to give to agriculture the variety and extent desired, or to attain any progress in a pursuit which in other colonies rapidly leads to riches.

Filipino farmers. The third consists of the principal mestizos and natives, and is in fact that⁹ which constitutes the real body of farming proprietors. In the fourth and last may be included all the other natives, who generally possess a small strip of land situated round their dwellings, or at the extremities of the various towns and settlements formed by the conquerors ; besides what¹⁰ they may have obtained from their ancestors in the way of legal inheritance, which rights have been confirmed to them by the present sovereign of the colony.

Aids to agriculture. It will beyond doubt, in some measure dissipate the distrust by which the Filipino is actuated, when the new and paternal exertions of the superior government, to ameliorate his present situation, are fully known, and when that valuable portion of our distant population is assured that their rights will henceforth be respected, and those exactions and compulsory levies which formerly so much disheartened them, are totally abolished. On the other hand, a new stimulus will be given by the living example and fresh impulse communicated to the provinces by other families emigrating and settling there, nurtured in the spirit and principles of those reforms in the ideas and maxims of government by which the present era is distinguished. A practical participation in these advantages will, most assuredly, awaken a spirit of enterprise and emulation that may be extremely beneficial to agriculture, and as the wants of the natives increase in proportion as they are enabled to know and compare the comforts arising out of the presence and extension of conveniences and luxuries in their own towns, they will naturally be led to possess and adopt them.

Plans for progress. So salutary a change, however, can only be the work of time, and as long as

the government confines itself to a system merely protecting, the effects must consequently be slow. As it is therefore necessary to put in action more powerful springs than the ordinary ones, it will be found expedient partly to relax from some of those general principles which apply to societies, differently constituted, or rather formed of other perfectly distinct elements. As relating to the subject under discussion, I fortunately discover two means, pointed out in the laws themselves, essentially just, and at the same time capable of producing in this populous colony, more than in any other, the desired results. The legislator, founding himself on the common obligation of the subject to contribute something in return for the protection he receives, and to co-operate in the increase of the power and opulence of the State, proscribes idleness as a crime, and points out labor as a duty; and although the regulations touching the natives breathe the spirit of humanity, and exhibit the wisdom with which they were originally formed, they nevertheless concur and are directed to this primary object. In them the distribution of vacant lands, as well as of the natives at fair daily wages to clear them, is universally allowed, and these it seems to me,

During the nineteenth century, the term "Filipino" was used to refer to Philippine-born Spanish⁹ residents in the colony. In the 1880s, the Propagandists appropriated this term for themselves.

Comyn was referring to Spanish conquerors such as Miguel Lopez de Legazpi, who arrived in the¹⁰ Philippines in the sixteenth century.

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are the means from an equitable and intelligent application of which the most beneficial consequences may be expected.

Confiscating unused lands. The first cannot be attended with any great difficulty, because all the provinces abound in waste and vacant lands, and scarcely is there a district in which some are not to be found of private property completely uncultivated and neglected, and consequently susceptible, as above stated, of being legally transferred, for this reason alone, to the possession of an active owner. Let their nature however, be what it may, in their adjudication, it is of the greatest importance to proceed with uniformity, by consecrating, in a most irrevocable manner, the solemnity of all similar grants. Public interest and reason, in the Philippine Islands, require that in all such cases deference only should be paid to demands justly interposed, and formally established within a due and fixed period; but after full and public notice has been given by the respective judicial authorities, of the titles about to be granted, the counter claims the natives may seek to put in after the lapse of the period prefixed, should be peremptorily disregarded. Although at first sight this appears a direct infringement on the imprescriptible rights of property, it must be considered that in some cases individual interests ought to be sacrificed to the general good, and that the balance used, when treating of the affairs of State, is never of that rigid kind as if applied to those of minor consideration. The fact is, that by this means many would be induced to form estates, who have hitherto been withheld by the dread of involving themselves, and spending their money in law suits; at the same time the natives, gradually accustoming themselves to this new order of things, would lay aside that disposition to strife and contention, which forms so peculiar a trait in their character, and that antipathy and odium would also disappear with which they have usually viewed the agricultural undertakings of Spaniards.

